The three bills were designed to allow private actors to invest and participate in agri-food supply chains. The farmers would ostensibly benefit from higher output prices. The first bill, accordingly, removed restrictions on the purchase and sale of farm produce, while the second bill removed restrictions on stocking, and the third bill then ushered in new laws to facilitate contract farming underpinned by written agreements. Given the complexities involved, which remained largely unexplained by the government, some lauded the three bills as bringing Indian agriculture into the modern era while others decried them as a final nail in the coffin of already struggling Indian farmers. What is true is that former Indian Prime Minister H.D. Deve Gowda was distinctly unhappy with the way in which the bills were rushed through Parliament. What is equally true is that they presaged a turning-point: an irrevocable and permanent withdrawal of state support for farmers in favour of the rapacious big business. Nothing seems to have been learnt from the British 'reforms' of a hundred years ago, and riots erupted in Punjab, which showed little signs of abating until the Government finally had to give in. [10] In the meantime, the Congress Party promised to reverse the 'reforms'. [11]

All this should have been forseen. It was forseen by Shekhar Gupta, the editor-in-chief of the well-regarded *The Print*, who at the time pointed out how, 'the Modi-Shah BJP does not understand Punjab, Punjabis, their politics, or even more specifically, the Sikhs.' He reminded everyone how 'Punjab was the outlier that defied the Modi magic in the north', because the BJP there lost the general elections of 2014 and 2019 even when it had 'a formidable ally, Shiromani Akali Dal, the pre-eminent Sikh party'. What he meant by this was that whereas 'on the farm bills, there is hardly a buzz in the other major farming states' such as 'Maharashtra, with massive agricultural population and an established record of farmer politics and protests', which 'is calm', the question that the farm laws was raising was: 'Why's Punjab angry? Because the state is different, as are the Sikhs.' In Punjab, the BJP government's 'politics of polarization' does not work, with the result that, '[t]he few Muslims who live in Punjab, in the tiny enclave of Malerkotla, have enjoyed the Sikhs' affection and protection since the times